Rachel Porter

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APPOINTMENTS

University *of* Notre Dame

Notre Dame du Lac Assistant Professor of Political Science 2024 –

Assistant Professor, Political Science 2022 –

Computational Social Science Fellow, Lucy Institute for Data & Society 2022 –

EDUCATION

The University *of* North Carolina *at* Chapel Hill

Ph.D., Political Science 2022

Fields: American Politics & Political Methodology

Dissertation: *Some Politics Are Still Local: Strategic Position Taking in Congress & Elections*

- Winner of the 2023 APSA E.E. Schattschneider Award

M.A., Political Science

The University *of* Georgia

B.A., Political Science & International Affairs 2016

- Phi Beta Kappa, Summa Cum Laude

BOOKS

Colin R. Case and Rachel Porter. *Latent Measurement from Text Data: Principles and Practices for Unsupervised and Weakly-Supervised Methods.* **Cambridge University Press,** Elements in Quantitative and Computational Methods in Social Sciences (Under Contract)

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

* = GRADUATE STUDENT COAUTHOR

[1] Colin R. Case and Rachel Porter. 2026. Strategic Heterogeneity in Issue Positioning: Evidence from Congressional Campaigns. Conditionally Accepted at **The American Journal of Political Science**.

[2] Rachel Porter, Jeffrey J. Harden, and Mackenzie R. Dobson*. 2025. Electing amateur politicians reduces cross-party collaboration. **Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences.**

- Coverage from The New York Times

[3] Colin R. Case and Rachel Porter. 2025. Conceptualizing and measuring early campaign fundraising in U.S. elections. **Political Science Research & Methods.**

[4] Rachel Porter, Colin R. Case, and Sarah A. Treul. 2025. CampaignView, a database of policy platforms and biographical narratives. **Nature: Scientific Data.**

[5] Rachel Porter, Jeffrey J. Harden, Emily Anderson*, Mackenzie R. Dobson*, Abigail Hemmen*, Géssica de Freitas*, and Emma Schroeder*. 2025. The Consequences of Elite Action Against Elections. **The British Journal of Political Science.**

[6] Rachel Porter and Sarah A. Treul. 2025. Evaluating (in)experience in congressional elections. **The American Journal of Political Science**.

- Top 10 most-cited article published in AJPS for 2024-2025
- Coverage from Brookings, Vox, FiveThirtyEight, ABC News, Politics in Question podcast

[7] Rachel Porter, Sarah A. Treul, and Maura McDonald. 2024. Changing the Dialogue: Descriptive Candidacies and Position Taking in Campaigns for the US House of Representatives. **The Journal of Politics.**

[8] Rachel Porter and Tyler Steelman. 2023. No Experience Required: Early Donations and Amateur Success in Congressional Primaries. **Legislative Studies Quarterly**.

- Top 10 most-cited article published in LSQ for 2023-2024

[9] Christina Ladam, Austin Bussing, Alexander Furnas, Josh McCrain, David Miller, and Rachel Porter. 2022. Junior Americanist Workshop Series. **PS: Political Science & Politics**.

[10] Maura McDonald, Rachel Porter, and Sarah A. Treul. 2020. Running as a Woman? Gender and the 2018 Congressional Election. **Political Research Quarterly**.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

Under Review

Colin R. Case, Emily C. Ommundsen, and Rachel Porter. Bipartisan Campaign Messages are Credible Policymaking Signals.

Jeffrey J. Harden and Rachel Porter. Information Limits in Observational Studies.

Rachel Porter, Ben Francis* and William Kakenmaster*. When Climate Hits Home: Local Economies and Pro-Environmentalism in Congressional Politics.

Working Drafts

Pamela Ban, Jaclyn Kaslovsky, and Rachel Porter. Elitism and Legislative Interaction.

James Bisbee, Patrick Y. Wu, Maggie Macdonald, Megan Brown*, and Rachel Porter. Small Dollars & Globalization: How Layoffs Translate to Costly Political Action.

Amy Brooke Grauley* and Rachel Porter. Identity-Linked Extremity: Candidate Positioning and Voter Inference in Congressional Elections.

Rachel Porter. *Some Politics are Still Local: How District Representation Persists in Nationalized Politics*. (Book manuscript)

Rachel Porter and Sarah A. Treul. *The Amateur Advantage: Unpacking the Rise of Political Inexperience in Congress & Elections* (Book manuscript)

OPEN DATA

CampaignView: U.S. House Campaign Website Archive (2018-2024)
`https://campaignview.org`

Early Fundraising in U.S. Congressional Elections (2008-2020)
`https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataset.xhtml?persistentId=doi:10.7910/DVN/FVLHCX`

U.S. House Candidate Biographical Data & Primary Election Outcomes (1980-2024)
`https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataset.xhtml?persistentId=doi:10.7910/DVN/CYFIDH`

BOOK CHAPTERS

[1] Jamie L. Carson, Jason M. Roberts, and Rachel Porter. 2020. "The Nationalization of Congressional Elections" in *New Directions in Congressional Politics*, Routledge.

[2] Michael S. Lynch, Anthony J. Madonna, and Rachel Surminsky. 2016. "Irregular Order: Examining the Changing Congressional Amending Process" in *Party and Procedure in the United States Congress*, Rowland & Little.

PUBLIC WRITING

Rachel Porter and Jeffrey J. Harden. 3 November, 2025. "Amateur hour in Congress: How political newcomers fuel gridlock and government shutdowns." *The Conversation*.

Rachel Porter and Sarah Treul. 22 April, 2024. "Evaluating (in)experience in congressional elections." *American Journal of Political Science - Author Summaries*.

Sarah Treul and Rachel Porter. 20 April, 2018. "Inexperienced candidates are becoming more common, but only in one party." *Mischiefs of Faction - Vox*

Rachel Surminsky and Michael S. Lynch. 20 November, 2014. "When Congress sues the president, it's likely to fail." *The Monkey Cage - Washington Post*

GRANTS & AWARDS

Awards & Honors

E.E. Schattschneider Award for best dissertation in American politics, APSA 2023
Earle Wallace Award for Graduate Student Teaching, UNC Political Science 2019
Phi Beta Kappa Honors Society, University of Georgia 2016

External Funding

Unite America Elections Reform Grant. Expanding CampaignView for 2026. 2025
Total Award: **$36,407**

Center for Effective Lawmaking Small Grant. Bipartisan Messaging in Elections. 2024
Co-PI with Colin R. Case and Emily Cottle Ommundsen
Total Award: **$1,000**

Unite America Elections Reform Grant. Measuring Issue Polarization. 2024
Co-PI with Colin R. Case
Total Award: **$21,745**

APSA Centennial Research Grant. JAWS CwC at MPSA. 2022
Co-PI with Austin Bussing, Leah Christiani, Zander Furnas, Christina Ladam, Josh McCrain, and David Miller
Total Award: **$10,000**

Social Science Research Council Social Data Dissertation Fellowship. 2020
Total Award: **$15,000**

Internal Funding

Notre Dame Democracy Initiative Grant **$25,000** 2025
Co-PI with James M. Curry and Jeffrey J. Harden
Notre Dame Franco Institute Small Grant. **$3,000** 2025
Notre Dame ISLA International Travel Grant. **$1,000** 2024
UNC Graduate School Dissertation Completion Fellowship. **$20,500** 2021
UNC Political Science Hughes Summer Research Award. **$2000** 2020
UNC Political Science Darlene Walker Summer Research Award. **$3000** 2019
UNC Political Science, Thomas M. Ulhman Fellowship. **$5000**/year 2016-2021
UNC Political Science, Summer Research Fellowship. **$3000**/year 2016-2021

TEACHING

University of Notre Dame

Instructor of Record

POLS 30005: The United States Congress FA 2023; SP 2024; SP 2025
POLS 40811: Quantitative Political Analysis SP 2023; SP 2024; SP 2025
POLS 60040: American Political Institutions (Graduate Seminar) FA 2022, FA 2024

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Instructor of Record

POLI 281: Data in Politics I FA 2019, SP 2020, FA 2020, SSII 2021

POLI 100: Introduction to American Politics SP 2019

Odum Institute for Research in Social Science
Short Course Instructor
Collecting & Analyzing Text in R SP 2019, FA 2019, SP 2020, FA 2020, SP 2021

PRESENTATIONS

Invited Seminars & Conferences

University of Rochester, Summer Conference in Applied Methods	(scheduled) 2026
University of Southern California, Primary Reform Conference	(scheduled) 2026
University of Notre Dame, Chambers of Democracy Conference	(scheduled) 2026
Michigan State University, MARGIE Conference	2026
University of Wisconsin-Madison, American Politics Workshop	2026
University of Toronto, Toronto Data Workshop	2026
Georgetown McCourt School of Public Policy, Seminar Series	2025
Indiana University - Bloomington, Center for American Politics Conference	2025
UChicago Harris School of Public Policy, Effective Governance Conference	2025
University of Michigan, American Institutions Group Workshop	2025
University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, American Politics Research Group	2025
University of Kentucky Martin School of Public Policy, Workshop Series	2025
University of Mississippi, Barbour Study of American Politics Conference	2025
Wesleyan University, Wesleyan Media Project Election Conference	2024
University of Virginia, Center for Effective Lawmaking Conference	2024
University of Notre Dame, Keeping the Republic Conference	2024
UC San Diego, American Politics Workshop	2024
UC Berkeley, Winter American Politics Research Meeting	2024
Washington University in St. Louis, Stories that Win Symposium	2024
Georgetown University, American Government Seminar Series	2023
Women in Legislative Studies (WiLS) Seminar Series	2023
University of Chicago, American Politics Workshop	2023
Purdue University, Political Science Workshop	2022
University of Oklahoma, Carl Albert Center Conference	2022
University of Notre Dame, Rooney Workshop Series	2021
Bowling Green State University, Speaker Series	2020
Washington University in St. Louis, Political Science Speaker Series	2020
University of Georgia, Emerging Issues in Political Science Speaker Series	2020

Annual Conference Presentations

MPSA	2017, 2018, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026
APSA	2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2026
PolMeth	(poster) 2018, 2019, 2021, 2022, 2023; (presentation) 2025
Women in Legislative Studies Conference	2023, 2025
State Politics & Policy Annual Conference	2024
CBS-Princeton Money in Politics Conference	2024
Visions in Methodology Conference	2024
Frontiers in Money and Politics APSA Pre-Conference	2021, 2023
Southern Political Science Association Annual Conference	2020

VOLUNTEER & SERVICE

Discipline Service

Co-Organizer, Notre Dame Chambers of Democracy Conference 2026
(*with James M. Curry and Jeffrey J. Harden*)

Co-Organizer, Shambaugh Conference on Congressional Elections 2026
(*with Colin R. Case and Sarah A. Treul*)

Co-Organizer, MPSA Primary Elections Mini-Conference 2024, 2025, 2026
(*with Sarah Anderson, Dan Butler, Colin Case, and Laurel Harbridge-Yong*)

Program Committee, PolMeth Annual Conference 2025
(*organized by Emory University*)

Program Committee, Visions in Methodology (VIM) Conference 2024
(*organized by Washington University in St. Louis*)

Co-Founder & Organizer, Junior Americanist Workshop Series 2020-2024

Co-Organizer, MPSA JAWS Mini-Conference 2023
(*with Austin Bussing, Leah Christiani, Zander Furnas, David Miller, Josh McCrain*)

Referee: *American Journal of Political Science; American Political Science Review; British Journal of Political Science; Electoral Studies; Journal of Elections, Public Opinion & Parties; Political Research Quarterly; Journal of Politics; JAMA Health Forum; Journal of Political Institutions and Political Economy; Journal of Women, Politics & Policy; Legislative Studies Quarterly*; National Science Foundation; *Policy Studies Journal; Perspectives on Politics, Political Behavior; Political Science Research & Methods; Politics & Gender; Research & Politics; Quarterly Journal of Political Science; Social Science Quarterly*

Discussant & Panelist: American Political Science Association Annual Meeting; Frontiers of Money & Politics Pre-Conference at APSA; Copenhagen Business School Money in Politics Conference; Junior Americanist Workshop Series; Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting; Society for Political Methodology Annual Meeting; Women in Legislative Studies Professional Development Seminar

Departmental Service at the University of Notre Dame

Co-Director, Representation and Politics in Legislatures Lab 2023-Present
Field Chair, Methods 2024-2025
Member, Committee on Inclusive Teaching, Learning, and Scholarship 2023-2024
Co-Chair, Undergraduate Thesis Awards Committee 2024
Admission Committee Member, Lucy Institute Graduate Fellows Program 2023
Member, Graduate Policy Council 2022-2023

Departmental Service at the University of North Carolina-Chapel Hill

Graduate Student President, Department of Political Science 2021-2022
Program Coordinator, American Politics Working Group 2018-2020
American Field Representative, Department of Political Science 2018-2019

Undergraduate and Doctoral Student Advising

Dissertation Committee Member

Emma Schroeder (Notre Dame; Defended April 2026)
Abigail Hemmen (Notre Dame; Defended April 2026)
Haley Cohen (Columbia University; Defended May 2025)

Methods Paper Committee Member

Géssica de Freitas (In progress)
Adriana Pilar Ferreira Albanus (In progress)

Undergraduate Mentoring

Senior Thesis Advisor, Thomas Musgrave (Defended 2025)
Senior Thesis Advisor, Erik Johansen (Defended 2025)
Senior Thesis Co-Advisor, Julia Thomalla (Defended 2024, Best Thesis Award Winner)

Last updated April 27, 2026